the other hand, was brought in for clear strategic reasons—to break the original Sharad Pawar-led party, as it had managed to do with the Shiv Sena, and also in the belief that Shinde alone would not be able to deliver in the Lok Sabha election.

As it turned out, neither did Ajit. The ruling Mahayuti faced a debacle in the May general election and the opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) walked away with 31 of 48 seats overall. The NCP itself won just one of the four seats it contested.

His alliance partners have now made their resentment clear. Articles in Sangh Parivar weeklies *Organiser* (English) and *Vivek* (Marathi) have openly expressed displeasure over the alliance. "The BJP claimed to be a party with a difference and yet had no inhibitions in allying with the NCP," says an RSS source, pointing to how it was the BJP leaders themselves who had earlier accused Ajit and his partymen of graft. "The BJP should have occupied the Opposition space," says a BJP minister. "Taking Ajit along and forming the government was a mistake."

The hatred has now begun spilling out. If Asha Buchke of the BJP greeted Ajit's cavalcade with black flags at Junnar in Pune in August, at another time, the Shiv Sena's public health minister Tanaji Sawant said that he felt like "throwing up" after sitting with NCP ministers. It upset Umesh Patil, the NCP spokesperson, so much that he said that it would be better if the party exited the government rather

INTERVIEW » **AJIT PAWAR**

"CM will be chosen after election"

As the assembly election looms in Maharashtra, deputy chief minister and NCP president Ajit Pawar shares his views with Senior Associate Editor Dhaval S. Kulkarni on a range of issues–the Mahayuti's CM candidate, his ambitions for the top post, a return to uncle Sharad Pawar. Edited excerpts:

On the Mahayuti's poll plank:
We are banking on welfare schemes like the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana. If the state government has the same ideology as the Union government, it helps the state get more funds and push development projects.

On the alliance's CM nominee:
Eknath Shinde is the CM and we two are the deputy CMs. We are facing the election together. The decision on the CM will be taken after the election.

On his chief ministerial ambitions:
I do not want to create new controversies by commenting on this. Our first target is to ensure that the Mahayuti gets the maximum number of seats.

On the economic rationale for schemes like Ladki Bahin:
Who is getting these benefits? Those with an annual income of under Rs 2.5 lakh, or around Rs 20,000 a month. What is wrong if we help them? Leakages in the system can be plugged and any ostentatious spending can be stopped.

On whether the Lok Sabha poll results will repeat themselves in the assembly:
Voters think differently in the Lok Sabha and assembly elections. In 1999, when simultaneous elections were held in Maharashtra, the Congress and NCP came to power in the state, and it was a BJP-led government at the Centre.

On inflammatory statements by BJP and Shiv Sena leaders:
I have referred to this in my speech at Buldhana where the CM and deputy CM were present... I speak out when

"I DID NOT HOLD DISCUSSIONS WITH THE SANGH BEFORE JOINING THE GOVERNMENT. I WAS IN TALKS WITH BJP'S SENIOR LEADERSHIP"

and where I need to. We have held discussions with their high commands, and the necessary changes will be made. This is not the position of our party or Mahayuti.

On the perceived unease in the RSS about allying with the NCP:
I did not hold discussions with the Sangh before joining the government. I was in talks with the BJP's senior leadership. Development and undertaking works in the constituencies of the MLAs were issues that were considered before joining the government.

On whether he or his son will contest from Baramati:
The party's parliamentary board will decide on this.

On a possible reconciliation with uncle Sharad Pawar:
This is speculative. Today, we are with the Mahayuti and are chalking out our journey accordingly.

On his softer version that is being projected through the NCP's Jan Sanman Yatra:
Earlier, I was working as an activist in the party, but now I am its president. As the party chief, I must modify the way I act and behave as my responsibilities have increased. Earlier, my seniors took care of things. Now, I have to do it.

On the speculation that his MLAs may defect to the NCP(SP):
This was also something that was being claimed during the legislative council election. But two of our candidates were elected though I was short of seven votes. This means that my MLAs are with me. We are working together to strengthen the organisation. ■